

Intersectionality case study paired analysis

Read the case study assigned to you in your breakout room, then answer the following questions (You will have 15 minutes for this discussion, before coming back to the main room)

- What identities / intersections do you notice?
- How does the structure of academia exclude them based on their identities?
- Implications for mentoring – how would you mentor this person? What resources are available for them? If you don't know, how would you find out?

Case 1: Ava – First-Gen, Latina, and Undocumented

Ava is a junior majoring in chemistry. She is a first-generation college student and an undocumented daughter of farmworkers. Although she is performing extremely well academically, she avoids applying for paid research jobs because she does not know whether she is eligible and does not want to have to disclose her status.

Case 2: Jay – Black, Nonbinary, and Neurodivergent

Jay is a graduate student in engineering who uses they/them pronouns and has ADHD. Jay is frequently misgendered by their labmates, which can cause Jay to react with frustration. As a Black student, their style of dress and way of speaking is already perceived as unprofessional, so Jay takes great care to mask their ADHD symptoms in the lab to avoid further scrutiny. This leaves Jay exhausted, which impacts their ability to concentrate.

Case 3: Priya – South Asian, Immigrant, and Caregiver

Priya is an Indian ecology postdoc. Her parents, who recently immigrated, have come to live with her, and she must now balance care-giving responsibilities with her work. Her PI consistently schedules last-minute meetings and is dismayed by her "inflexibility." Priya feels caught between the expectations of her culture, gender, and capitalism.

Case 4: Malik – Low-Income, Disabled, and Queer

Malik is a senior undergraduate who is visibly queer and uses a wheelchair. His advisor provided an opportunity to conduct field work in Jamaica, where there are laws against homosexuality. As a low-income student, he also cannot afford the upfront cost of the trip and the department has a reimbursement-only policy for travel. Malik's advisor keeps encouraging him to attend and does not understand why he wouldn't jump at the opportunity.